



The Sahara Desert

The world's largest hot desert, shaped by relentless winds and shifting sand dunes that are constantly on the move

Stretching from the Atlantic Ocean in the west to the Red Sea in the east, the Sahara covers almost all of North Africa. At 3.6 million square miles (9.4 million square km), it is slightly larger than the U.S., and surveys indicate that this vast, almost uninterrupted arid region is still expanding. Since 1962, the desert has grown by 250,000 square miles (647,500 square km).

More than sand

Although often associated with red sand dunes, most of the Sahara consists of barren, rocky plateaus called hamadas. These contain little sand, most having been swept away by the winds that continually transform the desert into a harsh landscape full of rocks, boulders, and gravel. In other areas, sand is piled up in dune



fields. The largest of these are called ergs—vast areas spanning more than 50 square miles (125 square km). Many contain shifting dunes, some as high as 490 ft (150m). Because ergs are highly active regions of loose sand, they are notoriously difficult to cross.

Several mountain ranges lie in the Sahara and many contain volcanoes. The desert also has gravel fields and salt flats, as well as dry river- and lakebeds.

Despite such harsh terrain and little to no rainfall—half of the Sahara gets less than 1 in (25 mm) a year, the rest possibly up to 4 in (100 mm)—around 500 plant and 70 animal species are found here.

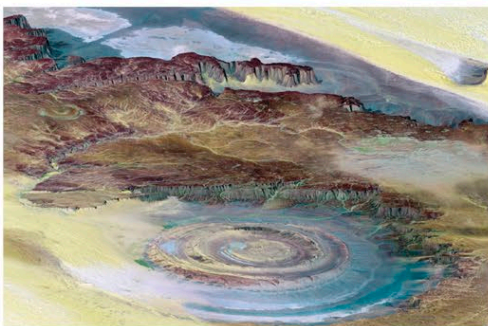
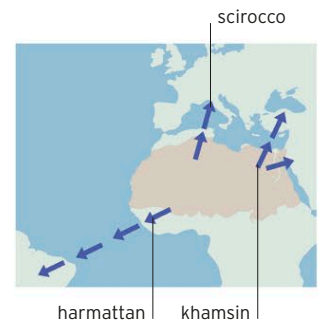
◁ DESERT FOX

The smallest of all foxes, the desert-dwelling fennec fox is the size of a house cat. Its massive ears keep it cool by releasing excess body heat.

Each year, **thousands of tons** of Saharan phosphorus dust reach the **Amazon rain forest**

DUST IN THE WIND

Saharan winds have a global impact, setting off weather events such as cyclones. The springtime scirocco blows damp, hot, dust-laden clouds and fog into southern Europe. The cool, dry, northeasterly harmattan carries tons of dust over the Atlantic during winter. The hot, dry khamsin blows into the Arabian Peninsula and southeast Europe from February to June.



△ BULL'S-EYE

The huge Richat Structure, known as the Eye of the Sahara, was thought to have been formed by a meteor strike. Scientists now believe it formed when igneous rocks were uplifted and later eroded.

◁ SAND WAVES

The red dunes of the Great Western Erg, near Taghit oasis, Algeria, resemble ocean waves. High winds here cause deadly sandstorms that can last for days.



◁ ROCKY PEAKS

At Tassili du Hoggar in southern Algeria, the central Saharan winds have sculpted a large sandstone plateau into jagged peaks, rock arches, and spires that resemble the ruins of a forgotten city.